
Handout: Thomas Nagel's "The Absurd"

I. What the Absurd is NOT (Common Misconceptions)

Nagel begins by dismissing standard arguments for why life is absurd. He argues that while the feeling of absurdity is correct, the usual reasons given for it are logically flawed.

- **The "Million Years" Argument:** People often say life is absurd because nothing we do now will matter in a million years.
 - *Nagel's Rebuttal:* If it doesn't matter *now* that it won't matter in a million years, then why worry about it? Furthermore, if our actions mattering *now* isn't enough, mattering in the future wouldn't help either.
- **The "Smallness/Brevity" Argument:** We are tiny specks in a vast universe, or our lives are mere instants in time.
 - *Nagel's Rebuttal:* If we lived forever, a life that is absurd at seventy years would be infinitely absurd if it lasted through eternity. Similarly, being physically larger (filling the universe) would not make life less absurd.
- **The "End of Justification" Argument:** Because we die, all chains of justification are cut off in mid-air (we work to eat, eat to work, etc.).
 - *Nagel's Rebuttal:* Justifications come to an end within life repeatedly, and this is usually sufficient. For example, taking aspirin for a headache requires no further justification to prevent it from being pointless.

II. Nagel's Definition of the Absurd

If the standard arguments fail, what constitutes true absurdity? Nagel argues that absurdity arises from a specific **collision within ourselves**.

The Two Components of the Collision:

1. **The Inescapability of Seriousness:** We cannot live human lives without energy, attention, and making choices. We take ourselves, our families, and our careers seriously, devoting decades of intense concern to them.
2. **The Inescapability of Doubt (The "Backward Step"):** Humans have the special

capacity to "step back" and survey themselves with detached amazement. From this external viewpoint, the seriousness of our specific aims appears gratuitous and arbitrary.

The Absurdity:

We continue to take life seriously despite the fact that we can view our lives as arbitrary and open to doubt.

"We see ourselves from outside, and all the contingency and specificity of our aims and pursuits become clear. Yet when we take this view and recognize what we do as arbitrary, it does not disengage us from life, and there lies our absurdity."

III. The Analogy to Epistemological Skepticism

Nagel compares the absurd to philosophical skepticism regarding our knowledge of the external world.

- **The Parallel:** Just as we can ask if the external world is real (or if we are dreaming), we can ask if our lives matter.
- **The Reality:** We cannot prove we aren't dreaming, yet we continue to believe in the floor beneath us. Similarly, we cannot prove our lives objectively matter, yet we continue to take aspirin for headaches and care about our futures.
- **The Result:** Philosophical skepticism doesn't make us abandon our beliefs; it just returns us to them with a "peculiar flavor" of irony and resignation.

IV. Failed Escapes and The Solution

Once we realize the absurd, how should we respond? Nagel analyzes three potential responses.

Response	Description	Nagel's Critique
1. Return to Animal State	Refusing to take the "backward step" or abandoning individual striving to live largely by impulse.	We cannot consciously "refuse" self-consciousness; we can't will ourselves to forget.

2. Suicide	Ending existence to end the absurdity.	This is a "hasty solution" to a problem that doesn't necessarily warrant such a drastic measure.
3. Defiance (Camus)	As proposed by Albert Camus: "shaking a fist at the world" and living in spite of the silence.	Nagel finds this "romantic and slightly self-pitying". It fails to appreciate the "cosmic unimportance" of the situation.

Nagel's Proposal: Irony

Nagel concludes that if there is no reason to believe anything matters *sub specie aeternitatis* (from the perspective of eternity), then "that does not matter either".

- We should approach our absurd lives not with heroism or despair, but with **irony**.
- The capacity to sense the absurd is actually one of the most advanced and human things about us.